

Clinical scenario for pain presentation HCF September 2013

1. Carol Smith is a 45-year-old care assistant in a local residential home for older people who presents in surgery complaining of worsening pain in her lower back during the past four weeks.
2. The pain is confined to her back and does not radiate down her leg. It becomes worse in the course of a day and sometimes wakes her at night. She also has some pain in her neck and right shoulder, and pain, longstanding but occasional, in her left knee when walking.
3. She dates her back pain to an episode in her workplace where she had to lift a patient off the floor unassisted. She offers the information that staff illness and absence rates in her workplace have been higher than usual in recent months, with change of personnel in the senior management of the home. 'It's not like it used to be – it's more stressed – there are not the people around to help with lifting and moving like before – but I still like the place.'
4. On questioning, Carol says her appetite and weight have been steady but she now wakes at night, has started to feel a bit low, and she gets more tired than before towards the end of the day. She has had episodes of back pain in the past but it has never lasted this long. She reports no fever, and no significant neurological symptoms or history of malignancy
5. She lives with her husband, a local council gardener, and her one child is enjoying work as a nurse in a town 20 miles away
6. She expresses her concern that she might be developing a long-term problem which will make her work difficult
7. On examination, she looks generally well and is moderately overweight; there is some curvature in the lower spine which disappears when she bends down to touch her toes – she can almost reach her toes but slowly and with some difficulty. She has some difficulty putting her hands behind her head
8. She tells you that a friend of hers had a scan and a special injection for her back pain which really helped. She wonders whether you think she should be referred to a specialist for this?